

the sellers had to drop the price to $\$2^{11/16}$ to attract the next buyer. Other sellers, seeing that no more deals could be made at $\$2^{11/16}$, were willing to lower their price to $\$2^{5/8}$. After the buyers disappeared at that level, somebody offered to sell for $\$2^{9/16}$. Meanwhile, people who'd refused to part with their Angstrom at $\$2^{3/4}$ were scared by the downturn and were dumping their shares at much lower prices.

When the price got so low that nobody was willing to sell—which I hoped would be soon—new buyers again would be forced to raise their bids in order to entice new sellers. This would cause the whole process to reverse, the stock would start moving in a favorable upward direction, and the smart money would be vindicated.

Soon I realized that the phrase "more sellers than buyers" only means that more people want to sell than to buy at the current price. If only I could contact the would-be sellers of Angstrom, to convince them of the big government contract in the works, they might stop driving the price down. If only I could find the people who sold me my 5,000 shares in the first place, I could tell them what I knew that they didn't, and maybe they'd get back into the stock.

It occurred to me that stock and bond sales are among the few transactions where one party is unable to meet the other party directly. Over cars, furniture, houses, clothes, jewelry, baseball cards, and other general merchandise, we're allowed to haggle face-to-face—buyers asking sellers why they are selling, sellers giving their reasons. Why couldn't we do the same with our equities? What's to stop us from gathering up shares from our safe deposit boxes, laying them out in the yard with the stereos and the roller skates, and putting up cardboard signs that say: TODAY ONLY, IBM AT $135 \frac{7}{8}$, 100 SHARES, OR GENERAL MOTORS, SPECIAL PRICE, 50 CENTS OFF AT \$65? What's to keep us from driving our stocks to the flea markets and trading them for water skis, or selling them outright for cash, and absent the broker's commission?

This idea got me so excited I called the Securities and Exchange Commission in their New York office and asked if it was legal to sell my shares at a garage sale. I was connected to a helpful attorney named Robert Anthony. "There's nothing to prevent that," he